

WARS

The human story is one of conflict. Disputes over territory, religion, and governance have escalated into war throughout history, and while the stories of great battles and great commanders make compelling reading, the tragic consequences of war should never be forgotten.

MAJOR WARS		
WAR	DATE	OPPOSING FORCES
Greek–Persian Wars	490–448 BCE	Coalition of Greek city-states including Athens and Sparta v. Persia
Peloponnesian War	431–404 BCE	Athens and allies v. Sparta and allies
Alexander the Great's Conquests	334–323 BCE	Macedonia v. Persian Empire
First Punic War	264–241 BCE	Rome and allies v. Carthage and allies
Second Punic War	218–202 BCE	Rome and allies v. Carthage and allies
Third Punic War	149–146 BCE	Rome and allies v. Carthage and allies
First Roman Civil War	49–44 BCE	Julius Caesar v. Pompey the Great
Second Roman Civil War	33–31 BCE	Octavian (Augustus) v. Mark Antony
Byzantine–Seljuk Wars	1064–71, 1110–17, 1158–76	Byzantines v. Seljuk Turks
The Crusades	1095–1272	Various Western European Christian armies v. Muslim states of the eastern Mediterranean and Egypt
Mongol Conquests	1206–1405	Mongols v. various European and Asian peoples
Hundred Years' War	1337–1453	English (and Burgundians) v. French
Onin War	1467–77	Yamana clan v. Hosokawa clan
The Italian Wars	1494–95, 1521–25, 1526–30, 1535–38, 1542–44	Italian city-states and Holy Roman Empire v. French and Italian allies
Wars of Japanese Unification	1560–1603	Oda Nobunaga, Toyotomi Hideyoshi, Tokugawa Ieyasu and allies v. opposing <i>daimyo</i> (warlord) clans
Eighty Years' War (The Dutch Revolt)	1568–1648	Dutch v. Philip II of Spain and allies in southern Netherlands
War of the Three Kingdoms (The English Civil War)	1642–51	Charles I and Royalists v. Parliamentarians
The Thirty Years' War	1618–48	Imperial Catholic alliance v. mainly Protestant powers plus France
The Great Northern War	1700–21	Sweden v. Denmark, Saxony, Poland–Lithuania, Russia
The Seven Years' War	1756–63	Britain and Prussia v. France, Austria, Russia, Saxony, Sweden
American Revolutionary War	1775–83	Britain v. American colonists (and French allies)
French Revolutionary Wars	1792–1802	France v. varying coalitions including Britain, Austria, Prussia, Russia
The Napoleonic Wars	1803–15	France v. varying coalitions including Britain, Austria, Prussia, Russia
Crimean War	1853–56	Russia v. Ottoman Turkey, Britain, France
The Indian Mutiny	1857–58	British v. native Indian forces
American Civil War	1861–65	The Union v. the Confederacy
Franco–Prussian War	1870–71	France v. Prussia

WAR	DATE	OPPOSING FORCES
Taiping Rebellion	1850–64	Chinese central (Qing) government v. Taiping rebels
Boer Wars (South African Wars)	1880–81, 1899–1902	British v. Boers (Afrikaners)
Balkan Wars	1912–13	[First] Bulgaria, Greece, Serbia, Montenegro v. Ottoman Turkey [Second] Bulgaria v. Turkey, Serbia, Greece, Romania
World War I	1914–18	Entente (Britain, France, Italy, Russia, US, and others) v. Central Powers (Germany, Austro-Hungary, and others)
Russian Civil War	1918–21	Bolsheviks v. "White" Russians
Spanish Civil War	1936–39	Nationalists v. Republicans
World War II	1939–45	Allies (British, French, and others) v. Axis (German, Japanese, Italians to 1943, and others)
Chinese Civil War	1945–49	Communists v. Nationalists (Kuomintang)
Korean War	1950–53	North Koreans and Chinese v. South Koreans and UN force (including Americans, Australians, and British)
French Indochina War	1946–54	French v. Vietnamese nationalists (Viet Minh)
Arab–Israeli Wars	1948–73	Israel v. Egypt, Syria, Jordan, Lebanon, Iraq, and Palestinians
Vietnam War	1961–75	South Vietnamese, Americans, and Australians v. North Vietnamese (Viet Cong)
Iran–Iraq War	1980–88	Iraq v. Iran
Gulf Wars	1990–91, 2003	Iraq v. international coalition led by US
Afghanistan War	2001–	US-led coalition v. Taliban

EXPLORERS

The “discoveries” of many early explorers were actually of lands that had thriving indigenous societies, which often led to disastrous results. Yet we can still admire the imagination and tenacity of those who risked their lives journeying into territory completely unknown to them.

NOTABLE EXPLORERS			
NAME	LIVED	ORIGIN	EXPEDITIONS/DISCOVERIES
Hanno	Active 5th century BCE	Carthage	Sailed down the west coast of Africa (c. 470 BCE)
Erik the Red	c. 950–1002	Norway	Explored the coast of Greenland (985)
Leif Eriksson	Active 11th century	Norway	Discovered Vinland, part of North America (c. 1000)
Marco Polo	1254–1324	Italy	Traveled extensively in China and along the Silk Road (1275–92)
Ibn Battuta	c. 1304–68	Morocco	Explored the Sahara, Arabia, India, Central Asia, China, and Southeast Asia
Dinís Diaz	Active mid-15th century	Portugal	Discovered the Cape Verde islands off the west coast of Africa (1445)
Bartolomeu Dias	c. 1450–1500	Portugal	Rounded Africa's Cape of Good Hope (1488)
Vasco da Gama	c. 1469–1524	Portugal	Sailed around Africa's Cape of Good Hope and reached India (1497–98)

